



MIDDLESEX Community College

Tools and Technologies for Tech Writers 2025

Homework Helpers

Notices

This document was prepared as a handout for the Middlesex Community College Tools and Technologies for Technical Writers class, Winter semester 2025.

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Homework Helpers

This course is very fast paced. A lot of the instructions are vague. This document is an attempt to flush out some details if you need it.

I reiterate this many times over the course: I am covering too much, too fast.

Every single topic I cover could be a full course unto itself.

The intention is that you learn a bit about how you need to learn whatever new tools come your way in the workplace. Do you need a few tutorials? Do you need to buy a book? Do you need someone to train you, hands on?

The other intention is that you figure out if there are tools you hate, so you know to avoid those when job hunting.

Note: This document will be updated each week with step by step instructions to complete the bare minimum homework requirement.

This document is meant to help you if you get stuck. If you perform the tasks in this document, you will pass. However, if all you do is the bare minimum, you won't get a lot out of the course. Your choice.

In this section:

- [Homework requirements](#) on page 4
For each assignment, I am looking to see if you tried to use the tool.
- [Building Blocks](#) on page 5
There are a handful of tasks you need to learn how to do in any program you work in.
- [Suggestion](#) on page 8
Make a simple set of content that you can keep reusing in different tools.
- [Assumptions](#) on page 9
These instructions assume the following:

Homework requirements

For each assignment, I am looking to see if you tried to use the tool.

It is impossible to master any of these tools in a week.

- I do not expect you to get everything correct.
- I do not expect you to become an expert.
- I do not expect this to be an excellent example of your writing abilities.
- I do not expect the assignment to be coherent or logical. It could all be Lorem Ipsum with some formatting applied.

My intention is that it only takes an hour or two to make a simple file (or more, depending upon the tool) that includes the following:

- At least one heading
- A paragraph or two
- An unordered list
- A numbered list
- A table
- Some inline formatting
- A link to an external file
- An image

This text can be completely nonsensical. I just want to see if you tried (not even succeeded) at using the tool.

[Building Blocks](#) on page 5 explains why I selected this set of items.

[Suggestion](#) on page 8 shows an example set of content.

These are the minimum requirements.

If you choose, you can attempt to use each homework assignment to make a portfolio piece. Pick something to document and write it up in whatever the tool of the week is. One of the easiest things to document might be something about whatever tool you are using. If you ask, I will review your content for writing style and offer suggestions.

Building Blocks

There are a handful of tasks you need to learn how to do in any program you work in.

Every tool, and every implementation of a tool, has a unique way of doing things. For example, many content sets require some way to link to the software application they are documenting. This is so if you click the help button in your application, a specific page in your output appears. Most tools offer a way to do this, however how you do it is unique to the tool. Also, what is specifically required is unique to your work place. You may need to set up a mapping file that links application IDs to help IDs, and then do something to add the help IDs to your source files so the "magic" works in the output. You may just need to ensure that output files are named a certain way or put in a certain folder.

That said, there are a relatively small list of things that you need to be able to do in every tool. If you can do these things, you can use the tool.

In this section:

- [As a Writer](#) on page 6

If all you are concerned with is writing, these are the basic tasks you need to know how to do.

As a Writer

If all you are concerned with is writing, these are the basic tasks you need to know how to do.

Required

This is the bare minimum you have to be able to do in any tool to be a technical writer.

- | | |
|----------------------------|--|
| Add a new paragraph | The English language is divided into chunks of text. These chunks are often paragraphs. You need to know how to make a new paragraph as needed. This is usually as simple as pressing Enter , but could require a bit more work, such as remembering to have a blank line between paragraphs in lightweight markup, or having to wrap the text in a <code><p></code> element in HTML. |
| Format the content | <p>As you author content, you need to add formatting to it to help present the information better. You need to know both what formatting to apply, as well as how to do it.</p> <p>Some of this is subjective, such as determining if the content work better as a series of paragraphs, a bulleted list, or a table.</p> <p>Some of this should follow your company's style guide, such as when to apply inline formatting, and knowing the name of the style for a third level heading.</p> <p>Some of this is knowing how your tool works.</p> <p>When I'm describing adding formatting here, in general, I'm referring to applying the formats, styles, or template in your tool. Designing what your format actually looks like is generally something different.</p> |
| Make text a title | The way we structure content in English, your content needs a title. This could be a chapter title, a book title, a section title, or a topic title. This could be done by applying a style to a paragraph, filling in the correct field in a form, or making sure the line of text has a line of equal signs underneath it. |
| Make a list | A lot of technical content requires lists of information: lists of prerequisites, lists of options, lists of things to do next. In many ways, this is just a specialization of <i>Format the content</i> . However, list items are very common. |
| Make a procedure | Many would state that this is the core of technical writing. Our main job is to tell people how to do things. This is often done via a procedure. This could be as simple as making a numbered list, or following a set of styles prescribed by your style guide, or the complex structure of a DITA task topic. Similar to <i>Make a list</i> , this is a specialization of <i>Format the content</i> , but there are often special tools or techniques for working with procedures. |
| Make a table | Tables are a great way to present certain types of information. They also tend to be very complicated. You need to learn how to insert, format, etc. Again, it's another specialization of <i>Format the content</i> , but they are tricky. If you're working with lightweight markup, it can be the most |

Insert an image

complicated formatting. Most tools have wizards and various tools that take some time to learn.

A picture is worth a thousand words. You will need to include images in your content. Different tools do this in different ways.

In general, there are two ways you need to consider inserting images: inline or separately. An inline image is used often in procedures to assist with instructions such as "Click the **Save** () icon".

For larger images, you need to insert them so that they stand alone. That could be inside of a figure with a caption, or just on a separate line. In rare cases, you may configure text wrapping to go around the image.

Insert a link

Content these days usually needs to refer to other things. This can be links to external web sites or links to other parts of your content. (Internal references are often called *cross-references*.)

Linking can be something you have to control manually, or it might be something that can be autogenerated by your tooling. It can also be something you may have to maintain over time, or maybe the tool helps you keep the links working.

Add inline formatting

Besides formatting giant blocks of text, such as paragraphs, lists, and tables, you often need to apply formatting to specific words or phrases in your giant blocks of text. Common examples include making things you click in your software bold, making variables italic, and making command names use a monospace font.

Structure your content

Most likely you don't have a lot to say about the big structure, such as new help systems, new books, or new output formats. However, within the area where you do have control, you will need to know how to structure your content. By structure, this generally means what makes a new section or chapter, and how section headings are nested. This could be making sure you use the right heading level style or could be structuring a bunch of topics into something that makes a table of contents.

Occasional

You may or may not need to do these tasks. These depend upon your tooling, your implementation, and how structured your work place is.

Make a new thing

Most of the time, as a technical writer you are working with content that is already semi-established. The User's Guide already exists, you're just adding new sections to it. You very rarely make a new thing. Also, there's usually a senior writer or information architect who minimally has extremely strong opinions and potentially corporate guidelines to follow about how new large things (new books, new help systems, new top level sections) can be created.

However, if you are working in a topic based system, you will probably often need to make new topics.

Update the table of contents	You will have to structure your content. Depending upon your tooling, your table of contents could be automatically generated, or something you have update. You may also need to be aware of your heading structures to make sure the table of contents works correctly. For example, some tools can't handle if your headings go from heading level 1 to heading level 3, skipping heading level 2.
Indexing or tagging for search	This may not make an actual index any more, but you probably need to do something to improve search results. This can be marking index terms, adding keywords, or adding tags.
Add context sensitive links	If you have a context sensitive help system, you need to add the markers or metadata or whatever to ensure your software can open the right page in your content. This could be something complicated to identify a help ID, or just making sure a file is named something specific.
Work with reuse	This is entirely tooling dependent, but if your tool allows for reuse, you should probably take advantage of it. Reuse can be many different things. You could have certain words or phrases that need to be inserted a specific way, such as version numbers or product names. You could have a way to share topics or chapters between different books. You could be able to reuse specific paragraphs, or any other defined chunk. You will need to learn both how to do the reuse in the tool you are using, and how your company maintains and organizes reused things.
Work with conditional text	Some tools allow you to mark content so that it only appears when certain conditions are met. This means you can mark content that only appears for specific outputs, such as between HTML or PDF output, or based on product or component.

Suggestion

Make a simple set of content that you can keep reusing in different tools.

Every single one of these homework assignments can be portfolio pieces. You can write complicated instructions on how to do things to show off what a great writer you are.

However, to pass this course, all you need to do is try to make all the basic building blocks in different tools.

When trying to learn the different tools, it might be easier if you just have text you are copying and pasting instead of trying to write something new *and* learn how to format something in yet another tool.

I would very much prefer you didn't cut and paste the following, but this is the minimal amount I'm looking for:

Look a Title

The above is a title. It could be formatted as something specifically labeled a title, or maybe just a heading level one.

This is another new paragraph with something **bold** and *italic*. I now have two separate paragraphs, and have some inline formatting.

- I also need a list.
- This is a second list item.

With a paragraph that lines up with the list item.

- And look, a third list item.

I have proven I can make an unordered list. And I can make another paragraph. Oh. I need a link to something, like <http://www.google.com>.

1. Now I need an ordered list.
2. I can use this for procedures.
3. Or to identify items in an image I don't want to translate.

There. Proof I can make a numbered list.



And there is an image. And I remembered to add alternative text.

Table Head 1	Table Head Column 2
Column 1	Column 2
More Column 1	More Column 2
And a third row for fun	With one more column 2

Assumptions

These instructions assume the following:

- You have already cloned the class repository and you are keeping it synced.
- You have Notepad++ installed.

Instructions are in Handouts/tips_and_tricks.pdf.

- You have modified Windows File Explorer to always show known file type extensions.
Instructions are in `Handouts/tips_and_tricks.pdf`.

Week 1: Getting Started with Git

The homework for week 1 is to set up your GitHub account.

The homework helper for this week is very minimal because I've tried to have a lot of information in various places.

- `mcc_tools_tech\Week01-IntroGitHub\Week1-IntroGitHub.html` presentation I use during class.

Yes, you are going to have access to all the presentations. While there are versions in existence for the entire class, so you can read ahead and be completely bored during class, but I am updating the presentations before each class, so things will change.

- `mcc_tools_tech\Week01-IntroGitHub\using_git.pdf` (*Using Git*) document that provides more detail than the presentation.

This document is also available in Blackboard.

- `mcc_tools_tech\Handouts\git_cheatsheet.pdf` (*Git Cheatsheet*) document that is more of a reference, but might give a detail in a different way that makes something click.
- <https://drive.google.com/file/d/1ij3FnYD-0f0TFgDDzeVpo74udtSKuTGJ/view?usp=sharing> – A video I threw together in 2022 to help you get started with GitHub.

Everywhere it says "Winter2022", you should use "Winter2025".

Many times in the work place, the training information is slightly out of date. Enjoy learning how to adapt to slightly inaccurate directions.

- [Syncing Repos in GitHub](#) – Another video about syncing repositories in GitHub I created in 2022. You probably don't need it for this week, but you'll definitely need it for next week.

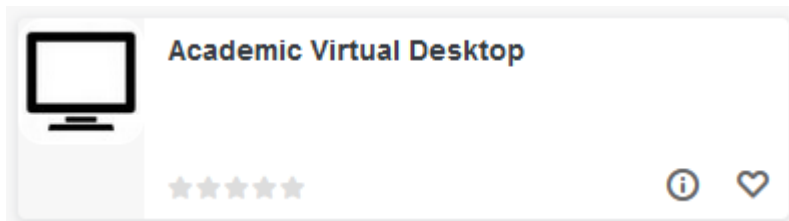
Everywhere it says "Winter2022", you should use "Winter2025".

Using the Virtual Desktop

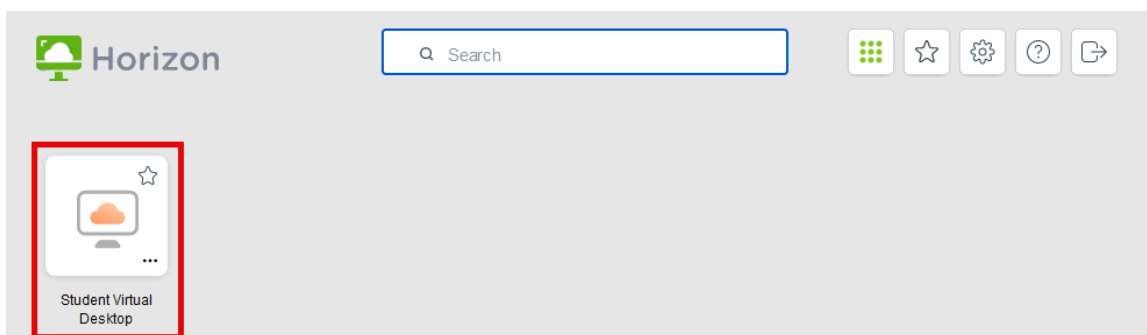
Middlesex Community College provides a virtual student desktop to access applications provided by the school.

The virtual desktop gives you access to all the Microsoft Office applications and Techsmith Camtasia.

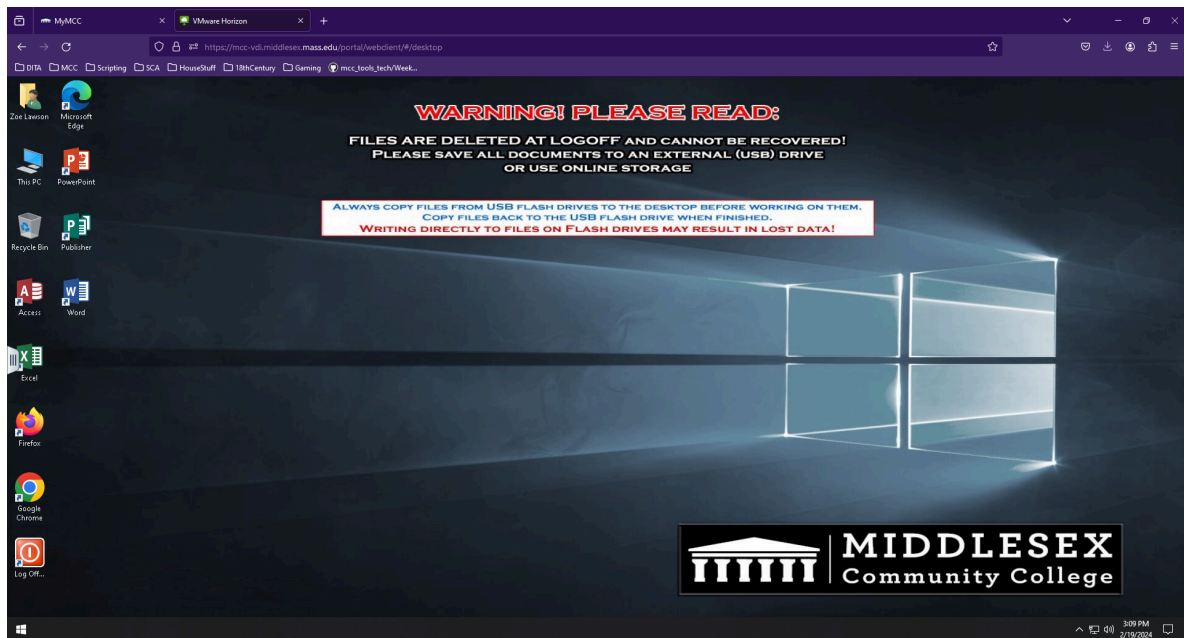
1. Log in to MyMCC (<https://mymcc.middlesex.edu/>).
2. Click **Academic Virtual Desktop**.



3. Sign in to MCC (again).
4. Click **Student Virtual Desktop**.



5. You may be prompted to choose between the desktop client and the browser client. This example uses the browser client.



You now have access to the virtual desktop in your browser window.

Remember that while you might be able to save files locally, there is no guarantee they will still be there the next time you log in. Save any work to your own cloud drive (OneDrive, Google Drive, etc.), or take advantage of the GitHub.com browser tools.